I think there was some pent-up anger in me over Carter's claims that I was a racist and warmonger. Just as he'd distorted my view on states' rights and arms control, he had distorted it regarding Medicare, and my response just burst out of me spontaneously.

The audience loved it and I think Carter added to the impact of the words by looking a little sheepish on the television screen.

To me, the finish of the debate was probably more significant: In my closing statement, I asked people if they thought they were better off now than they had been four years earlier. If they were, I said they should vote for my opponent; if not, I said I thought they'd agree with me that it was time for a change.

After a final week of campaigning, Nancy and I returned to Los Angeles for election day and to await the people's decision. It was our tradition to have dinner on election night with a small group of old friends at the home of Earle Jorgensen, who'd been a member of my Kitchen Cabinet in Sacramento, and then drive over to our campaign headquarters to wait out the returns.

Late that afternoon, I was in the shower, getting cleaned up for the evening, when Nancy, who'd already taken her bath and was wrapped in a towel, came into the bathroom and shouted above the drizzle of the shower water that I was wanted on the telephone.

"It's Jimmy Carter," she said.

I turned off the water and got out of the shower and dried off a little, then grabbed an extension phone in the bathroom while Nancy stood beside me.

After listening for a few minutes, I said, "Thank you, Mr. President."

Then I hung up the phone and looked at Nancy and said, "He conceded. He said he wanted to congratulate me."

Instinctively, she gave me a big hug and I hugged her.